

Road to 100K MTT Game Plan

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The plan in brief

Play about 150 small-field and turbo tournaments a month at a \$5 average buy-in, picked so they finish before work, and move up only when the bankroll says so. Early levels are tight and cheap, the middle is where chips are won, and the late stages are played for pay jumps first and the win second.

Three rules keep the challenge alive through the downswings every tournament player gets:

1. Average buy-in stays at 1 percent of the bankroll and no single entry goes above 2 percent.
2. Six buy-ins lost in a block ends the registering for that block.
3. No shots and no "one big Sunday". The schedule's registration cutoff is the only clock that matters.

Tournament selection

Pick by expected finish time and field size first, prize pool last. Everything below registers between 9:00 and 11:00 am and is done before 2:30 pm on a normal run.

Format	Buy-in	Field	Length	When	Why
Turbo	\$3 to \$5.50	100 to 500	2 to 3 h	Monday to Thursday blocks, 2 to 3 at a time	Volume and a guaranteed finish; lowest variance per hour
Regular speed, small field	\$5 to \$7.50	under 500	3 to 4.5 h	Friday and Saturday, registered by 10:00 am	Deeper play, better hands for the episode
Progressive bounty	\$5	200 to 800	3 to 4 h	One per recorded block	Knockouts pay early, soften the variance, and make clips
6-max turbo	\$3 to \$5	under 300	2 h	Fill-ins when a block has a gap	Short, aggressive, good for practising short-stack play

Avoid for now

- Hyper-turbos: the edge is small and the variance is not.
- Fields over 1,000 or anything starting after 11:00 am: the finish lands in work time.
- Satellites: a ticket is not bankroll.
- Rebuy tournaments with unlimited rebuys in the first hour: the real buy-in is three times the sticker.

Re-entry rule: at most one re-entry per event, only in the first hour, only if the field is still under 500, and it counts toward the block's six-buy-in stop-loss. Never re-enter a turbo past level 6.

Stage-by-stage strategy

The stack in big blinds, not the level number, tells you which row you are in.

Stage	Stack	Goal	Preflop	Postflop	Mistake to avoid
Early levels	80 bb and up, no antes	Lose nothing big; see cheap flops in position	Open 2.5x from late position with a wide range, tight from early. Flat small pairs and suited connectors in position. 3-bet only for value.	Pot control with one pair. Stack off only with two pair plus, sets, or strong draws.	Playing a big pot with top pair against a limper who check-raises. They have it.
Antes kick in	40 to 80 bb	Steal blinds and antes; build a stack without showdowns	Open 2.2x to 2.5x. Widen from the cutoff and button. 3-bet light against players who open and fold.	Continuation bet small on dry boards, check back wet boards without equity. Barrel turns that improve your range.	Calling 3-bets out of position with hands that make one pair.
Middle	25 to 40 bb	Keep the stack above 25 bb; pick the spots you control	Open 2x to 2.2x. 3-bet shove 20 to 25 bb over late-position opens with pairs, ace-x suited, broadways. Stop flatting raises from the blinds with junk.	Fewer streets: bet-fold or check-call lines, not three-barrel bluffs.	Flatting with 25 bb and folding the flop. That is how stacks leak.

Stage	Stack	Goal	Preflop	Postflop	Mistake to avoid
Short	12 to 25 bb	Shove or fold first in; re-shove over openers; stop open-raising below 15 bb	Push-fold charts from the desk. Shove wider from late position, tighter from early. Call shoves only inside your chart.	Rarely applies. If you raised and got called, commit with any pair or draw by the flop.	Min-raising with 12 bb and folding to a shove.
Bubble and pay jumps	Any	Survive as a short stack; punish as a big stack	See the ICM section. Tighten calls, widen shoves when covered players are folding.	Avoid flips against stacks that cover you.	Calling a shove with ace-jack on the bubble because "it's a flip".
Final table	Any	Ladder, then win	Pressure medium stacks when you are big. As a medium stack, avoid the big stack and attack the shorts.	Play fast with strong hands; the pots are big relative to pay jumps.	Playing for first when three pay jumps are in front of you with a short stack.
Heads-up	Any	Win	Raise the button with most hands; defend the big blind wide. Shove under 15 bb with any ace, king, pair, or suited connector.	Bet when checked to. One pair is a strong hand.	Folding too much on the button.

Micro-stakes exploits

At \$5 the field is not balanced, so the plan is not balanced either. Each adjustment below is a response to something the population does, and it stays in the plan only while your Monday reviews keep confirming it.

What the field does	Your adjustment
Limps a lot, then calls raises with anything	Isolate limpers to 4x plus one blind per limper with hands that flop well. Never limp behind without a plan.

What the field does	Your adjustment
Calls down with any pair or any draw	Value bet thinner and bigger: 70 to 80 percent of the pot with top pair good kicker on dry boards. Bluff rivers almost never.
Rarely bluffs big on the river	When a passive player bets big on the river, fold one pair. When they check-raise, fold two pair on most boards.
Over-shoves short stacks with weak aces and suited junk	Call shoves a little wider than the chart with pairs and strong aces when you cover; fold the same hands when the shove covers you.
Does not adjust to antes	Steal more from the cutoff and button once antes start. Most players keep their early-level ranges all tournament.
Stacks off with top pair in deep pots	Set-mine and play suited connectors in position early. Fold top pair to a check-raise at 80 bb plus.
Ignores the bubble	Shove wider when you cover the players behind you; they are calling at chip-EV, which is wrong, so tighten your own calls.

Stack-depth rules

One sizing per depth, so there is nothing to think about preflop except the hand.

Effective stack	Open size	Big blind defence	3-bet	First-in rule
60 bb and up	2.5x	Defend wide against late-position opens, tight against early	Value only, 3x the open (4x out of position)	Raise or fold; no limping
30 to 60 bb	2.2x to 2.5x	Call with hands that flop well; 3-bet or fold the rest	Polar: strong hands and some suited aces, 3x	Raise or fold

Effective stack	Open size	Big blind defence	3-bet	First-in rule
20 to 30 bb	2x to 2.2x	Call rarely; shove over late opens with pairs, ace-x suited, broadways	Shove or fold, no small 3-bets	Raise or fold; plan to commit by the flop
15 to 20 bb	Min-raise with hands that can fold; shove the rest	Shove or fold against a min-raise from late position	Shove	Mostly shove; min-raise only the top and the bottom of your range
Under 15 bb	Shove	Shove or fold	Shove	Shove or fold, from the push-fold chart on the desk

Two checks before any shove: how many players are left to act, and who covers whom. The same 14 bb that is a shove from the button is a fold from under the gun, and a shove into a bigger stack costs the tournament while a shove into a shorter one costs chips.

Bubble and final table

Independent chip model (ICM) in one sentence: chips you lose are worth more than chips you win once pay jumps are near, so calling gets tighter and shoving gets wider, in proportion to how many players you cover.

As the big stack

- Open and shove into medium stacks relentlessly; they cannot call you without risking their tournament.
- Leave the other big stack alone. A flip between the two biggest stacks is the worst spot at the table.
- Keep pressing after the bubble bursts; the same players stay tight through the first three pay jumps.

As a medium stack

- Avoid the big stack. Fold hands you would otherwise play if the big stack is still to act.

- Attack the short stacks when they are folding to survive, and tighten against the ones who are shoving any two.
- Do not call off for your tournament life with a hand that is only a flip, whatever the pot odds say.

As the short stack

- Shove before the blinds reach you, not after. A 7 bb stack has fold equity; a 4 bb stack does not.
- Pick the spot by position and who is behind you, not by the cards. Any two cards from the button into two tight blinds beats ace-ten from under the gun into six players.
- If a pay jump is one elimination away and a shorter stack exists, fold almost everything until it is gone.

Final table order of business: ladder past the short stacks first, then play for the win once you are top three in chips. Pay jumps at a \$5 tournament's final table are often bigger than a whole day's buy-ins, so a fold that costs chip-EV and banks a jump is usually right.

Block rules

These are the rules of a block, written down so they are not decided at the table.

- ☐ Check the tracker's suggested average buy-in and the single-entry cap before registering anything.
- ☐ Register between 9:00 and 11:00 am only, late registration included. Nothing after 11:00.
- ☐ Two to four tables. Add a table only when one busts, never because a hand went badly.
- ☐ Stop-loss is six buy-ins per block, re-entries counted. Hit it and finish the tournaments you are in, then close the lobby.
- ☐ One re-entry per event at most, first hour only, field still under 500.
- ☐ Two bust-outs inside twenty minutes means a five-minute walk before the next registration.
- ☐ Say "clip that" on mic after any hand worth showing. Note the clock time if the recording is off.
- ☐ Log the block as one tournament session in the tracker before closing the client: total buy-ins, total cashes, hours, episode number, events played in the notes.

What the numbers say

At 150 entries a month with the average buy-in held at 1 percent of the bankroll, the bankroll grows by 1.5 times your return on investment each month. A 20 percent return compounds at about 30 percent a month; a 10 percent return at about 15 percent. That is the whole engine, and it is why volume and the 1 percent rule matter more than any single score.

Milestone	Strong run (20% return to \$2,500, 15% to \$10,000, 10% after)	Modest run (10% return throughout)
\$1,000	Month 3	Month 5
\$2,500	Month 6	Month 12
\$5,000	Month 10	Month 17
\$10,000	Month 13	Month 22
\$25,000	Month 20	Month 28
\$50,000	Month 25	Month 33
\$100,000	Month 30	Month 38

Read the table as a shape, not a promise. Returns fall as buy-ins rise, downswings of 50 buy-ins will push you down a rung at least once, and the months are only real if the 150 entries are. A two to three year challenge is the honest framing for the channel, and it is a better series than a six-month sprint that ends at zero.

Track these, in the tracker's notes until there are enough entries to mean something

- Entries per week: target 35.
- In-the-money rate: 15 to 20 percent is normal at \$5; below 12 percent over 300 entries means the early-stage play needs work.
- Return on investment: ignore it until 500 entries. Before that, judge the month on entries played, stop-losses honored, and the Monday review done.
- Average buy-in against the 1 percent rule, checked every Sunday.